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The role of partners and children for employees' daily recovery☆,☆☆

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ABSTRACT

This multi-source diary study examined the role of partners for employees' daily recovery in a sample of dual-earner couples. We hypothesized that employees' daily psychological detachment from work during the evening should be positively associated with their partners' daily psychological detachment during the evening. Employees' affective well-being (serenity and negative activation) at bedtime should be influenced not only by their own psychological detachment, but also by their partners' psychological detachment. Moreover, we hypothesized that the presence of children in a couple's household should moderate the relations between partners' psychological detachment on the one hand, and employees' psychological detachment and affective well-being on the other hand. Fifty-three dual-earner couples completed daily electronic surveys via handheld devices at bedtime over the course of one work week. We used dyadic multilevel path modeling to analyze our data. Results showed that employees' and their partners' levels of daily psychological detachment were positively related. Employees' psychological detachment predicted their own negative activation, but not their serenity at bedtime. Partners' psychological detachment predicted employees' serenity and negative activation only in couples without children. Hence, our study provides support for the relevance of partners and children for employees' daily recovery after work.

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Since World War II, the percentage of dual-earner households has increased markedly (Whitehead, 2008). Nowadays, in European countries and the United States, the dual-earner pattern prevails among couples living together in a household and many of these dual-earner couples have children living in their home (UNECE Statistical Division Database, 2009). In dual-earner couples both partners face the challenge of juggling their job and their home demands (e.g., ten Brummelhuis, Haar, & van der Lippe, 2010). After a busy day at work, both partners strive to recover from job stress to recharge their batteries for the next work day. Being able to switch off from work during off-job time (i.e., psychological detachment) is crucial for employees' recovery (Sonnentag, 2012). Thus, in dual-earner couples both partners need to find ways to switch off from work during the evening to recover from job stress.

Previous research showed that employees' overall perception of their ability to detach from work and their global assessment of their well-being may be influenced by their partners' general ability to detach from work (Hahn & Dormann, 2013). However, these

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global assessments of employees' psychological detachment reflect employees' general—more trait-like—long-term recovery strategies; hence they cannot give insight into employees' daily—more state-like—psychological experiences and short-term recovery processes as they unfold. Although the relationships between employees' and their partners' psychological detachment and well-being do not necessarily have to be different when examined on a daily short-term level, it is important to study both long-term and short-term processes to arrive at more comprehensive understanding of employees' and their partners' recovery.

Moreover, prior research showed that there is a substantial intraindividual variation in employees' psychological detachment from day to day. For example, daily diary studies show that typically between 42 and 50% of the variance in psychological detachment is due to intraindividual variation (e.g., Sonnentag & Bayer, 2005; Sonnentag & Binnewies, 2013; Volmer, Binnewies, Sonnentag, & Niessen, 2012). It is unclear if and how the fluctuations in employees' and their partners' daily psychological detachment affect employees' and their partners' daily recovery processes.

The present study addresses this question by investigating the role of partners for employees' recovery processes with a daily diary design. More specifically, we examine if fluctuations in partners' daily psychological detachment from work are related to employees' daily psychological detachment and well-being at bedtime. Additionally, as many dual-earner couples have children in their homes, we consider the role of children for dual-earner couples' recovery processes. As having children may reduce the time couples spend together and may draw their attention away from each other (cf. Song, Foo, & Uy, 2008), we examine if the relation between partners' psychological detachment and employees' psychological detachment and well-being is the same for couples with and without children. Thus, we examine the presence of children as moderator.

Our study will contribute to the literature in several ways. First, our study with its daily diary design will allow capturing the short-term aspects of partners' influence on employees' daily recovery processes. Hence, our study will go beyond prior research that examined the influence of partners' psychological detachment on employees' psychological detachment and well-being focusing on general recovery strategies or experiences (Hahn & Dormann, 2013). Our daily diary study will help to gain more insight into the role of partners in employees' daily recovery as the diary design offers the unique possibility to track psychological effects as they unfold (Bolger, Davis, & Rafaeli, 2003).

Second, our diary study allows us to study the dynamics of employees' and their partners' daily recovery processes by examining fluctuations *within* couples. Studying fluctuations in employees' and their partners' recovery does not only allow for investigating the implications of these fluctuations for employees' and their partners' well-being, but can also help to rule our one alternative explanation for the association between both partners' recovery experiences. Hahn and Dormann (2013) acknowledged that their finding of a positive relation between employees' and their partners' general psychological detachment could be due to assortative mating or selection effects rather than to a true influence of the partner. Their cross-sectional between-couple design did not allow ruling out this alternative explanation. As we focus on fluctuations *within* couples, our daily diary design can rule out this alternative explanation. Finding within-couple relationships between partners' psychological detachment and employees' psychological detachment and well-being thus can make us more confident that partners indeed influence employees' recovery processes.

Third, by studying the presence of children in a couple's home we aim at capturing employees' social context more completely. Only recently, scholars began to acknowledge the importance of the social context for employees' recovery from job stress (Hahn, Binnewies, & Haun, 2012; Park, Fritz, & Jex, 2011). Given that many couples have children in their home, it is important to consider the role of children—as important members of the social context—in employees' recovery.

1. The recovery concept

Dealing with job demands and expending effort to fulfill work tasks deplete employees' resources throughout the workday and lead to strain reactions (Meijman & Mulder, 1998). After work, employees usually have time to rest and recover from job stress. Recovery is a process opposite to the stress process as it reduces and reverses the harmful effects of job demands (Sonnentag & Fritz, 2007). During recovery periods, short-term stress reactions can be offset and hence it can be prevented that short-term stress reactions develop into long-term health problems (Meijman & Mulder, 1998). A growing body of empirical research demonstrates that recovery processes during off-job time benefit employees' short-term as well as long-term well-being and health (see Koch, Hahn, & Binnewies, 2013). Additionally, research shows that being recovered is associated with employees' engagement and performance at work (Binnewies, Sonnentag, & Mojza, 2009a; Sonnentag, 2003).

Recovery can occur when no demands similar to employees' preceding job demands are put on the employees (Meijman & Mulder, 1998) and when drained resources are replenished or when new resources such as energy or self-regulation are built up (Hobfoll, 1989). As being exposed to job stressors can lead to impaired affective states such as high negative activation and low positive affect (e.g., Ohly & Schmitt, 2013), successful daily recovery after work which undoes these strain reactions becomes evident in increased positive affective states and low negative affective states at bedtime (Sonnentag & Geurts, 2009).

Employees' affective experiences both at work and at home states can be described in the context of Russell's (1980) circumplex model which differentiates between affect of positive and negative valence on one dimension and high and low activation on the second dimension. Prior research showed that employees' recovery processes are associated with affective states from all four quadrants of the affective circumplex (Fritz, Sonnentag, Spector, & McInroe, 2010; Hahn et al., 2012; Sonnentag, Binnewies, & Mojza, 2008). However, not all affective states from all quadrants of the affective circumplex are equally suited for studying recovery at bedtime. For example, while it is desirable that employees feel positively activated in the morning when they start to work, feeling activated at bedtime might impair employees' ability to fall asleep (Morin, Rodrigue, & Ivers, 2003). Hence, in this study, we focus on the affective states of serenity and negative activation because these affective states seem particularly able to reflect employees' affective well-being at bedtime. Serenity refers to a state of positive affect and low arousal, while negative activation is described as a state of negative affect and high arousal. At bedtime, employees who have recovered from job stress after work should not feel tense or distressed anymore (i.e., they should feel low negative activation) and they should feel calm and at ease (i.e., they should feel high serenity). Feeling serene and free of tension should also help employees to achieve a good night's sleep as high arousal and negative emotions before going to sleep impair sleep quality (Akerstedt et al., 2012; Morin et al., 2003).

2. Psychological detachment from work during off-job time

Sonnentag and Fritz (2007) proposed that the experience of psychological detachment from work during off-job time plays a crucial part in employees' recovery processes. *Psychological detachment from work during off-job time* (hereafter, *detachment*) is described as mental disengagement from work during off-job time (Sonnentag & Bayer, 2005). Detachment implies that employees refrain from job-related activities (e.g., checking job-related e-mails) and do not think about job-related issues such as unfinished work tasks (Sonnentag, 2012). Poor detachment from work manifests itself in work-related rumination and worrying (Flaxman, Ménard, Bond, & Kinman, 2012). For example, employees may ruminate about a conflict they had with a colleague or they may worry about upcoming projects or deadlines.

In line with previous research (e.g., Sonnentag & Bayer, 2005), we propose that employees' daily detachment during the evening should be associated with their affective well-being at bedtime. When employees do not detach from work during the evening, they cannot recover from job demands as the cognitive representations of the job demands remain activated (Flaxman et al., 2012; Meijman & Mulder, 1998). Hence, job demands continue to draw on employees' resources and the psychological and physiological exposure to perceived job demands is prolonged (Flaxman et al., 2012). As a consequence, recovery cannot occur (Meijman & Mulder, 1998), and employees still feel negatively activated when going to bed and they are unable to arrive at a state of serenity and calmness at bedtime. Moreover, when employees keep thinking about job-related issues after work, they are less likely to become fully immersed in family activities or other preferred leisure activities which might help them to replenish their resources (Hobfoll, 1989; Ilies et al., 2007). As a result, employees may find it difficult to enjoy and capitalize on otherwise probably pleasant leisure activities that may increase their positive affect (Gable, Reis, & Elliot, 2000). Previous research provided evidence for the relation between detachment and reduced negative activation (Sonnentag & Bayer, 2005; Sonnentag et al., 2008) as well as some evidence for the relation between detachment and serenity (Fritz et al., 2010).

Hypothesis 1. Employees' daily psychological detachment is associated with employees' a) increased serenity, and b) decreased negative activation at bedtime.

3. The role of partners' psychological detachment

When employees cannot detach from their work, they often ruminate or worry about work-related issues. Previous conceptual and empirical research suggests that rumination or worrying involve interpersonal processes (Calmes & Roberts, 2008; Parkinson & Simons, 2012). Rumination or worrying does not have to be solitary activities, but can be enacted as part of social interactions (Parkinson & Simons, 2012). For example, individuals share their worries with their partners to get comfort or support. In order to support a partner who has to deal with problems at work, employees may think about similar problems and how they coped with them. Hence, when partners do not detach from work and ruminate about work-related issues, employees may discuss the problems in a contemplative manner with them; that is, employees may co-ruminate with their partners (Calmes & Roberts, 2008). Moreover, when partners do not detach, but talk about their work, they may not only prompt employees to co-ruminate with them, but also generate cues that prompt employees to think about their own work. For example, when one partner mentions that she must not forget to finish a task, the other partner may recall unfinished work projects and start ruminating about work.

In addition, when partners cannot detach from work, they may not only share their work-related thoughts with employees and thus stimulate rumination; they may also fail to facilitate employees' detachment. When individuals cannot forget about their work, they may be unable or reluctant to fully engage in distracting joint activities with their partners that facilitate detachment. For example, individuals preoccupied with their work-related thoughts may be absent-minded and withdrawn. Story and Repetti (2006) showed that on days of high job stress—which are typically the days when individuals show low detachment from work (Sonnentag & Bayer, 2005)—individuals were more withdrawn and less responsive to their partners. Prior research showed that becoming absorbed in joint activities with the partner facilitates detachment (Hahn et al., 2012). However, becoming truly absorbed in joint activities and finding distraction may be hindered when one person is absent-minded and withdrawn. Hence, on days when individuals do not detach from work, they are less likely to help their partners find distraction from work-related thoughts.

There is cross-sectional between-couple evidence for the relation between partners' general level of detachment and employees' general level of detachment (Hahn & Dormann, 2013). We propose that this relation should also exist at a daily basis at the within-couple level.

Hypothesis 2. Partners' daily psychological detachment is positively associated with employees' daily psychological detachment.

Moreover, we expect partners' detachment during the evening to be associated with employees' well-being at bedtime (i.e., increased serenity and decreased negative activation). When partners think about their work during the evening, they may be less available for pleasant joint activities (e.g., doing sports, going out together) that may help employees to build up drained resources and improve their affect. Additionally, when partners are preoccupied with their work, they may be less available to provide instrumental or emotional support to employees that might help employees to unwind from job stress and improve their impaired affect. Moreover, when employees notice that their partners do not detach from work, their partners' work-related worries may elicit an empathic reaction in them (Parkinson & Simons, 2012). When employees take their partners' perspective and feel their partners' job demands and worries, their negative activation should increase and serenity should decrease.

Previous research provided first support for the notion that partners' lack of detachment may influence employees' well-being. Hahn and Dormann (2013) found that partners' detachment was associated with employees' well-being with their between-couple design. Regarding within-person findings, a diary study by Jones and Fletcher (1996) showed that husbands' daily preoccupation with work was associated with wives' negative affect.

Hypothesis 3. Partners' daily psychological detachment is associated with employees' a) increased serenity, and b) decreased negative activation at bedtime.

4. The moderating role of children in the home

In our study, we also focus on the role of children to more completely capture employees' private social environment. The presence of children influences employees' and their partners' home lives (Song et al., 2008). Hence, we consider the presence of children in the home as a boundary condition for the effects of partners' detachment on employees' detachment and well-being. We expect that the influence of partners' detachment on employees' detachment and well-being is weaker when there are children living in the home.

First, couples with children have less shared leisure time and spend less time alone as a couple (Hill, 1988). Due to their parental responsibilities, couples with children may have less freedom and opportunities to pursue distracting activities together. Partners in couples with children are more likely to be engaged in different activities at home (e.g., one person washes the dishes while the other person bathes the children; Hallberg, 2003). An observation study of dual-earner families by Campos, Graesch, Repetti, Bradbury, and Ochs (2009) showed that mothers and fathers spend substantial time with their children alone without their partners. Second, having children in the home requires couples to take on additional roles and responsibilities, which can shift both partners' attention away from each other (Song et al., 2008). Consequently, employees may not realize their partners' lack of detachment when they are distracted by their children and thus may be less affected by their partners' lack of detachment. Third, the presence of children may alter a couple's interaction behaviors. For example, couples may avoid discussing job-related worries when their children are present, which might reduce the chance that employees catch up their partners' work-related thoughts and are stimulated to think about their own work.

Previous studies provide empirical support for the moderating role of children in the home. Song et al. (2008) found that children in the home reduce the daily crossover of negative affect from one spouse to another. Using a general time perspective, Hahn and Dormann (2013) found first evidence that children in the home weakened the relation between employees' and their partners' detachment.

Hypothesis 4. Children in the home moderate the relation between employees' psychological detachment and their partners' psychological detachment. When there are children in the home, the relation is weaker.

Hypothesis 5. Children in the home moderate the relations between partners' psychological detachment and employees' a) serenity, and b) negative activation. When there are children in the home, the relations are weaker.

5. Method

5.1. Overview

Both partners of heterosexual dual-earner couples first completed a general paper-and-pencil survey assessing demographic data before they filled in daily surveys on handheld devices (iPod touch®) at bedtime over a period of five workdays. To reduce participant burden and increase the likelihood of participation, we limited the diary period to five days following the example of recent daily diary studies among couples (e.g., Neff, Sonnentag, Niessen, & Unger, 2012; Sanz-Vergel, Rodríguez-Muñoz, Bakker, & Demerouti, 2012).

5.2. Sample and procedures

Participants consisted of employees from various German organizations and their partners. To recruit study participants, we contacted managers from various organizations (e.g., local and federal government, financial administration, university administration, job agencies, and health insurance companies) and informed them about our study. After managers expressed interest in participation, all employees received an information leaflet about our study on "work–life balance among working couples". The leaflet included information about eligibility criteria for study participation (living with a partner and both partners working at least three days a week) and a web-link to register for participation. All employees decided individually if they fulfilled the criteria and if they and their partners wanted to participate. As the managers did not know how many employees fulfilled the eligibility criteria, we were unable to calculate response rates in each organization. Participants were promised feedback on the study results and entered a lottery drawing of cinema tickets as incentive for study participation. During the online registration, we screened out participants who did not meet the eligibility criteria for study participation.

Upon registration, we sent general paper-and-pencil surveys to employees and their partners with pre-stamped return envelopes and scheduled a week for collecting daily survey data with the handheld devices. During face-to-face meetings, we explained the functioning of the handheld devices to the participants. To remind them of completing the daily surveys, we programmed alarms on the handheld devices. In addition, we asked participants to coach their partners on how to complete the surveys and program the daily alarms. We also asked participants to fill in all surveys without discussing their answers with their partners.

Overall, 63 couples who met the eligibility criteria signed up for study participation. As ten couples resigned from participation due to personal reasons (e.g., death in the family, sudden prolonged illness of one partner, unexpected business trip), we sent paper-and-pencil survey packages to 53 couples and scheduled a time period for the daily surveys. We received paper-and-pencil surveys from all 53 couples (106 individuals). The 106 individuals (53 couples) completed 496 electronic daily surveys at bedtime (out of 530 possible diaries). The handheld devices recorded the time when participants answered the daily surveys. We excluded 60 surveys that were filled in at the wrong time (e.g., the next morning). We matched the remaining 436 individual daily surveys to a pairwise daily data file consisting of 240 days. On 46 days, we had data from one partner of the couple only. We excluded 12 days in which partners indicated that they had not seen each other during the evening. Thus, our final data file comprised 228 days.

Our final sample consisted of 53 heterosexual couples who had been living together for 10.7 years on average ($SD = 7.7$). The female partners were on average 38.1 years old ($SD = 9.1$), the male partners were on average 41.4 years old ($SD = 9.3$). Thirty-four couples had children living in their household with them. Our sample was fairly well-educated with 47% of the women and 55% of the men holding a university degree. Women worked an average of 32.5 h a week ($SD = 8.4$), men worked an average of 39.3 h a week ($SD = 2.7$). Due to our recruitment strategy, the participants working in the organizations we approached mainly had administrative jobs at local and federal government agencies, financial administration, university administration, job agencies, and health insurance companies. The partners had more diverse occupational backgrounds (e.g., manager, dentist, nurse).

5.3. Measures

We assessed demographic information (age, gender, occupation, presence of children in the home) with the general paper-and-pencil survey. Daily detachment and affective well-being were measured with electronic daily surveys that were completed at bedtime.

5.3.1. Psychological detachment

We assessed psychological detachment from work during the evening using the respective four-item subscale from the Recovery Experience Questionnaire (2007). We used the version that was adapted for daily use (see Sonnentag et al., 2008). All items were answered on a five-point Likert scale. A sample item was "Tonight, I distanced myself from my work". Cronbach's alpha averaged across all days was .91 among men and .88 among women.

5.3.2. Affective well-being

Serenity and negative activation were measured using the respective subscales of the PANAS-X (Watson & Clark, 1994). Serenity was measured with three items (e.g., "calm", "at ease"), negative activation was measured with six items (e.g., "afraid", "nervous", "distressed"). In order to limit participant burden, we used the six-item short version of the negative affect scale that has been used in earlier studies (e.g., Sonnentag & Binnewies, 2013; Sonnentag et al., 2008). Participants responded to all items on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (*not at all*) to 5 (*very much*) with respect to their state "now, before going to bed". For serenity, Cronbach's alpha averaged across all days was .79 among men and .88 among women. For negative activation, Cronbach's alpha averaged across all days was .81 among men and .77 among women.

To examine if serenity and negative activation constitute distinct constructs, we conducted a set of multilevel confirmatory factor analyses using Mplus 7 (Muthén & Muthén, 1998–2012). We performed these analyses for men and women separately. For men, a two-factor model with all items loading on their respective factors (i.e., serenity and negative activation) yielded an acceptable fit, $\chi^2 = 128.32$, $df = 53$, $p < .001$, $RMSEA = .08$, $CFI = .91$. This two-factor model fit the data better than the one-factor model with all items loading on one factor, $\Delta\chi^2\ (2) = 48.64$, $p < .001$. Similarly, for women a two-factor model with all items loading on their respective factors (i.e., serenity and negative activation) yielded an acceptable fit ($\chi^2 = 127.13$, $df = 53$, $p < .001$, $RMSEA = .08$, $CFI = .90$) and fit the data better than the one-factor model, $\Delta\chi^2\ (2) = 100.02$, $p < .001$. Taken together, these results show that serenity and negative activation clearly represent distinct constructs among both men and women.

5.4. Data analytic strategy

Dyadic diary data are inherently nonindependent (Laurenceau & Bolger, 2012). There is nonindependence between both dyad members on the one hand and nonindependence of the daily surveys within each dyad member on the other hand. Following the recommendation of Laurenceau and Bolger (2012), we modeled a multivariate two-level model with the daily observations of both dyad members nested within the dyad to take both sources of nonindependence (persons in dyads and daily observations in persons) into account. This type of model combines features of the actor–partner interdependence model and individual diary analyses (for a detailed description see Laurenceau & Bolger, 2012). The actor–partner interdependence model (APIM) takes the interdependence of persons in a dyad into account as it states that a person's independent variable affects both his or her own dependent variable (actor effect) and his or her partner's dependent variable (partner effect) (Kenny, Kashy, & Cook, 2006). To test our main effect hypotheses, we ran a series of multilevel models in Mplus 7 (Muthén & Muthén, 1998–2012) where both men's and women's daily affective states were predicted by men's and women's fluctuations in daily detachment (Level 1). To be able to disentangle within-couple and between-couple effects, we regressed men's and women's outcomes on their mean levels of detachment (Level 2). For these analyses, we created stable Level 2 variables of men's and women's mean levels of daily detachment by averaging their daily detachment scores across all days. This procedure allowed us to decompose the influence of detachment into two effects: one reflecting the pure within-person (or within-couple) association between detachment and affective states, the other reflecting the between-person (or between-couple) association between detachment and affective states. For testing our moderator hypotheses, we used multi-group analyses comparing couples with children to couples without children (Jaccard & Wan, 1996).

6. Results

Means, standard deviations, and zero-order correlations are displayed in Table 1. For calculating the correlations between day-level and person-level variables, day-level variables were averaged across the five days. We used centered scores of detachment for calculating the correlations to make the correlations more comparable to our hypothesis testing analyses in which we used person-mean centered predictor variables.

We also examined the variability of our study variables across the five days for men and women (ICC). For detachment, ICC = .59 for men and ICC = .44 for women. For serenity, ICC = .44 for men and ICC = .48 for women. For negative activation, ICC = .45 for men and ICC = .25 for women.

6.1. Preliminary analyses

Before testing our hypotheses, we tested if men and women were empirically distinguishable. Although the dyad members in our study are conceptually distinguishable by their gender, scholars recommend to test for empirical distinguishability, that is, whether the conceptual distinction by gender actually matters in terms of observed differences in means, variances, and covariances in the study variables for the dyad members (Ackerman, Donnellan, & Kashy, 2011; Kenny et al., 2006). We performed omnibus tests of distinguishability for both outcome variables (serenity and negative activation) in which we compared the fit of a model in which means, variances, and covariances of the predictor and outcome variables were constrained to be equal across both partners of a dyad to a model in which they were free to vary (Ackerman et al., 2011). As we had multilevel data, we implemented equality constraints on means, variances, and covariances on both the within and between-couple levels. The first omnibus test of distinguishability including detachment and serenity showed no significant differences between men and women in a dyad, χ^2 (11) = 11.83, p = .38. The second omnibus test of distinguishability including detachment and negative activation did not show significant differences between men and women either, χ^2 (11) = 13.27, p = .27. These results imply that men and women cannot be empirically distinguished. Hence, we treated men and women as indistinguishable when testing our hypotheses, that is, we constrained means, variances, as well as actor and partner effects to be equal across men and women.

6.2. Test of hypotheses: within-couple relations

To test Hypotheses 1 to 3, we estimated two models using serenity and negative activation as outcomes. The parameter estimates are displayed in Figs. 1 and 2. Both models with serenity (χ^2 = 11.83, df = 11, p = .38, $RMSEA$ = 0.02, CFI = 0.98) and with negative activation as outcome (χ^2 = 13.27, df = 11, p = .28, $RMSEA$ = 0.03, CFI = 0.96) showed a good fit to the

Table 1
Correlations between study variables.

	Variables	*M*	*SD*	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	Children[a]	0.27	0.96	−.15	.14	−.02	.19	−.05	−.27
2	Psychological Detachment$_{Man}$	3.59	1.17		.09	.42**	.06	−.33*	−.38*
3	Psychological Detachment$_{Woman}$	3.83	1.03	.25**		.33	.37	−.17	−.44**
4	Serenity$_{Man}$	3.56	0.78	.05	.06		.20	−.77**	−.39**
5	Serenity$_{Woman}$	3.47	0.91	.10	.11	.20**		−.19	−.62**
6	Negative activation$_{Man}$	1.31	0.55	−.11	−.01	−.66*	−.13		.42**
7	Negative activation$_{Woman}$	1.30	0.48	−.08	−.08	−.33*	−.54**	.39**	

Note. [a]−1 = no, 1 = yes. Within-couple correlations are displayed below the diagonal. Group-mean centered scores of psychological detachment were used to calculate correlations. Between-couple correlations are displayed above the diagonal. Grand-mean centered scores of psychological detachment were used to calculate correlations.
*p < .05. **p < .01.

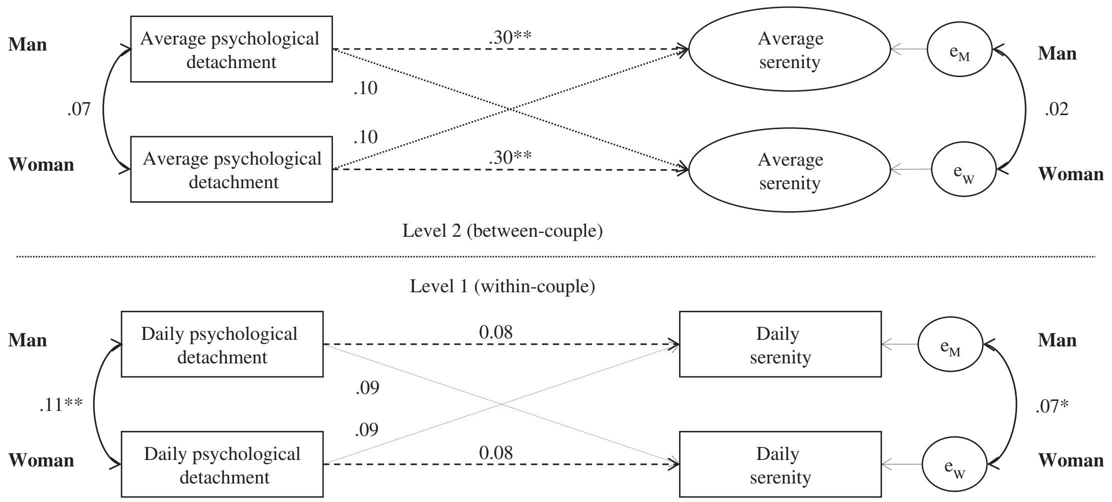

Fig. 1. Men's and women's psychological detachment predicting serenity. *Note.* Actor effects are indicated by dashed lines. Partner effects are indicated by dotted lines. $^{*}p < .05$. $^{**}p < .01$.

data. Our first hypothesis stated that fluctuations in employees' daily detachment should be related to increased serenity and decreased negative activation. Employees' daily detachment was not associated with their serenity, $b = .08$, $SE = .05$, $p > .05$, but was negatively associated with their negative activation, $b = -.07$, $SE = .03$, $p = .02$. Thus, Hypothesis 1 was supported for negative activation as outcome only. Hypothesis 2—which stated that fluctuations in employees' daily detachment should be positively associated with fluctuations in partners' detachment—received support, too ($b = .11$, $SE = .03$, $p < .01$).

Hypothesis 3 stated that fluctuations in partners' detachment should be associated with employees' serenity and negative activation. We found no significant relations between partners' detachment and employees' serenity, $b = .08$, $SE = .05$, $p > .05$, as well as employees' negative activation, $b = -0.01$, $SE = .03$, $p > .05$. Thus, Hypothesis 3 was not supported. Hypotheses 4 and 5 stated that the relations between partners' detachment on the one hand and employees' detachment and affective states on the other hand should be moderated by the presence of children in the home. To test these hypotheses, we performed multi-group analyses comparing couples with and without children. For each hypothesis, we constrained the specific path to be equal for couples with and without children and compared this model to a model without this constraint. For the relations between employees' and their partners' detachment, we found no significant difference between couples with and without children, $\Delta\chi^2$ $(1) = 0.66$, $p > .05$. Thus, Hypothesis 4 was rejected. Regarding the relations between partners' detachment and employees' serenity, the chi-square difference test comparing couples with and without children showed a significant difference, $\Delta\chi^2$ $(1) = 6.01$, $p < .05$. For couples without children, there was a significant relation between partners' detachment and employees' serenity, $b = .26$, $SE = .09$, $p < .01$, while for couples with children, there was no significant relation, $b = .03$, $SE = .06$, $p = .96$. For the relations between partners' detachment and

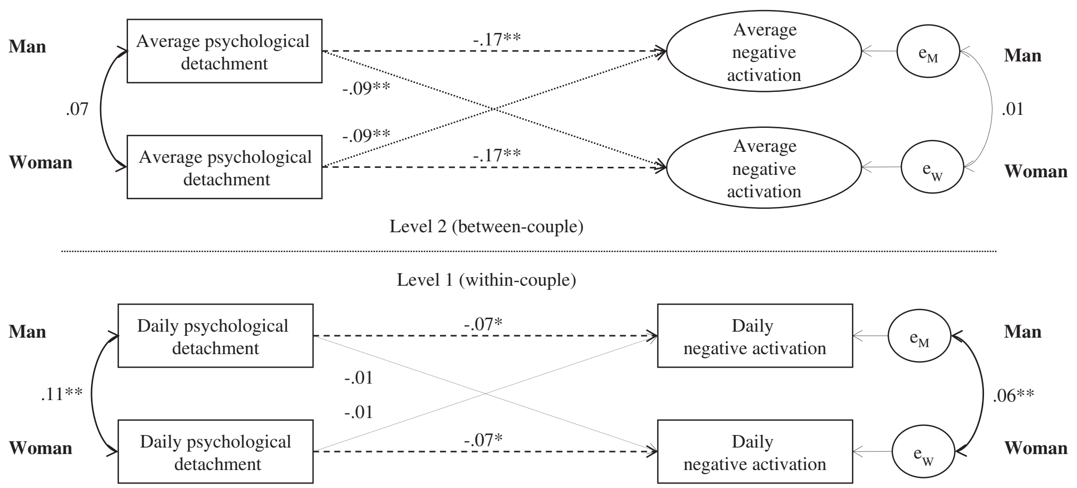

Fig. 2. Men's and women's psychological detachment predicting negative activation. *Note.* Actor effects are indicated by dashed lines. Partner effects are indicated by dotted lines. $^{*}p < .05$. $^{**}p < .01$.

negative activation, the chi-square difference test comparing couples with and without children also showed a significant difference, $\Delta\chi^2$ (1) = 6.44, $p < .05$. For couples without children, there was a significant relation between partners' detachment and employees' negative activation, $b = -0.13$, $SE = .06$, $p < .05$, while for couples with children, there was no significant relation, $b = 0.04$, $SE = .04$, $p > .05$. Thus, Hypothesis 5 was fully supported.

6.3. Between-couple relations

Although the focus of our study was the investigation of within-couple relations between partners' detachment and employees' detachment and well-being, we simultaneously estimated between-couple effects in our models to be able to disentangle within-couple effects from between-couple effects. For the sake of completeness, the parameter estimates of the between-couple effects are displayed in Figs. 1 and 2 in the upper part of the models. We did not find a significant relation between men's and women's detachment. For serenity as outcome, we found significant effects for employees' own detachment, but not for partners' detachment. For negative activation as outcome, we found that both employees' and their partners' detachment predicted employees' negative activation.

7. Discussion

This diary study with dual-earner couples examined the role of partners and children for employees' daily recovery during the evening. To the best of our knowledge, our study is the first study to examine the influence of partners on employees' recovery from a daily short-term perspective. We found that fluctuations in partners' daily detachment were positively associated with fluctuations in employees' daily detachment. When one partner ruminates about his or her work, the other partner may be stimulated to ruminate about work as well. On the one hand, when one partner ruminates and talks about work, he or she may create cues that remind the other partner of his or her work. Hence, one partner's ruminative thoughts may cross over to the other partner. On the other hand, as a reaction to their partners' lack of detachment, employees might to try to be socially supportive in the face of their partners' work problems. To support their partners, they might think of similar situations in their work and thus fail to detach from work. Individuals that have similar jobs or work for the same employer as their partners may be particularly able to support their partners (Halbesleben, Zellars, Carlson, Perrewé, & Rotondo, 2010); however, they might also be particularly likely to be affected by their partners' lack of detachment. Future research could test the idea that relations between both partners' detachment is stronger when both partners are work-linked.

As we focused on fluctuations within both partners' daily levels of detachment, we can be more confident that employees and their partners truly influence each other's recovery processes. Prior cross-sectional research (Hahn & Dormann, 2013) could not rule out the possibility that relations between employees' and their partners' general levels of detachment are due to assortative mating or selection effects and thus do not reflect partners' mutual influence on each other. However, we found a positive link between fluctuations in employees' and their partners' detachment around their *average* level of detachment. This finding cannot be attributed to assortative mating. Thus, although we cannot strictly infer causality from our results and experimental research is still in need, we can be much more confident about the notion that partners in a couple influence each other's recovery processes.

Partners' detachment is associated with employees' decreased negative activation and increased serenity in couples without children in their home, but not in couples with children in the home. Hence, the presence or absence of children in the home seems to be a boundary condition for the relation between partners' detachment and employees' well-being. Interestingly, the presence of children did not moderate the relation between employees' and their partners' detachment. This pattern of results suggests that even when there are children in the home and employees and their partners spend less time together, employees notice their partners' lack of detachment and are stimulated to think about their own work. However, employees with children may have fewer opportunities to react empathetically to their partners' work worries; thus, their affect at bedtime is not directly influenced by their partners' lack of detachment. Moreover, it is likely that on days when employees detach from their work, they have more energy that they can invest into their private lives. When employees do not have children, they may invest their energy in the relationship with their partner which in turn improves their partners' well-being; however, that might not be the case if there are children in the home as employees may invest their energy into interactions with their children. Hence, in couples with children in the home, employees may not benefit from their partners' detachment.

We found employees' own daily detachment to be associated with their negative activation at bedtime. In line with previous research (Fritz et al., 2010; Sonnentag et al., 2008), this finding supports the notion that rumination about one's work prevents unwinding from job-related negative activation during the evening. Contrary to our expectation, employees' detachment was not associated with their serenity. However, Sonnentag et al. (2008) did not find a relation between daily detachment and serenity either. These results suggest that on a daily level, a lack of detachment may result in increased negative activation; however, employees may not necessarily experience the absence of work-related thoughts (i.e., detachment) as positive experience that induces serenity. On the between-level we found employees' detachment to be related with both their negative activation and serenity. This result is in line with the between-person findings of Fritz et al. (2010). On a general level, employees' recovery strategy of detachment may not only imply the absence of work-related thoughts, but might also reflect engagement in distracting positive activities that might explain relations with serenity. These findings reflect that the effects of employees' general more trait-like recovery strategies may differ from the effects of daily fluctuations in employees' recovery experiences and thus underlines the importance of studying dual-earner couples' recovery processes both within and between couples.

7.1. Limitations and implications for future research and practice

In our study, we focused on the presence of children in the home as boundary condition for the relation between partners' detachment and employees' well-being. However, we did not assess how much time employees actually spent with their children and how this family time was spent. Examining the presence or absence of children in the home cannot give insight into the mechanisms of how children actually influence their working parents' recovery processes. Prior research suggests that children's experiences (e.g., stress at school, conflicts with peers) influence their interactions with their parents (Chung, Flook, & Fuligni, 2011; Lehman & Repetti, 2007). Hence, taking a closer look at parents' interactions and experiences with their children could explain additional variance in employees' recovery processes. Future research should focus on employees' interactions and experiences with their children to shed more light on the influence of children on employees' recovery.

Although we found evidence for a relation between partners' detachment and employees' negative activation and serenity, we do not know much about the mediating mechanisms, that is, employees' and their partners' behaviors. Several questions remain unanswered. For example, did partners engage less in joint activities with employees when they were preoccupied with work-related issues? Did employees and their partners actually talk about their work? Future research should examine couples' interaction behaviors (e.g., if they discuss positive or negative work events with their partners) to clarify the mediating mechanisms.

Our study was based on the premise that refraining from work-related thoughts benefits employees' well-being. However, there is first evidence that detachment might be associated with certain costs as it prevents the spillover of positive work events and moods into the home domain (Sonnentag & Binnewies, 2013) and thus may prevent capitalization on positive events and the crossover of positive moods to the partner (Song et al., 2008). Future research should not only consider benefits, but also potential costs of detachment for employees and their partners and aim to identify the situations when low detachment might be beneficial for both partners' well-being. Prior research also suggests that reflecting positively about one's work has beneficial effects on one's well-being and detachment (Binnewies, Sonnentag, & Mojza, 2009b; Bono, Glomb, Shen, Kim, & Koch, 2013). Hence, one partner's positive thoughts about his or her work could also have beneficial effects on the other partner's mood, particularly when they are shared (Hicks & Diamond, 2008). Future research should refine the concept of detachment and distinguish between positive and negative forms of work-related thoughts and their effects on employees and their partners (cf. Binnewies et al., 2009b).

Our findings suggest that employees and their partners should be aware that their detachment is not only relevant for their own, but also for their partners' recovery from job stress. Hence, employees and their partners may try to leave their work behind and gain distance from their work in the evening. Engaging in absorbing joint activities with the partner may be one way to foster detachment (Hahn et al., 2012). These suggestions are particularly important for couples without children. In addition, couples—especially those without children—might try to spend time with friends or other family members on days when they have problems switching off from work. On the one hand, being with friends or family members may help employees and their partners to detach from work (ten Brummelhuis & Bakker, 2012). On the other hand, being with friends or family members may have similar effects as being with children. The company of friends and family members may prevent one partner's lack of detachment from affecting the other partner's well-being. Moreover, as prior research shows that focusing on positive events may foster detachment (Bono et al., 2013) and sharing positive events with the partner may benefit both partners' well-being (Hicks & Diamond, 2008), couples may try to focus on the positive aspects of their work on days when they find it difficult to detach from work.

In sum, although more research is needed to replicate our findings, our study is a first step to highlight the role of partners and children in employees' daily recovery. Our study supports the notion that employees' social context matters for their daily recovery. Hence, scholars should take employees' social context into account to arrive at a better understanding of employees' recovery processes.

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